

film review

Loud and Long

HALLA BOL

Director: Raj Kumar Santoshi

Starring: Ajay Devgan, Pankaj Kapur, Vidya Balan

Activist films are perfect showcases for stars who want to be more than pin-ups. Not only do they allow them rousing climactic speeches which display their acting chops but also act as mea culpas for the crass comedies done for money.

On the face of it, *Halla Bol* is a fine specimen of this genre, peeling the mottled skin off a thoroughly unpleasant industry, with its compromised stars, corrupted ethics and fake bonhomie. From taking potshots at stars who sell body oils and do item songs at weddings (guess who?) to exposing the real meaning of auditions for starlets and rehearsals for intimate scenes.

But suddenly the film morphs from a *Page 3* clone, a voyeur-friendly



LUMBERING ON: Balan and Devgan

ringside view of the Bollywood underbelly, to a *Rang De Basanti*-crusade film even as the weak-kneed star rediscovers the steel in his spine. Devgan goes from a suave, soap and *gutka*-selling star, taking a brave and ironic look at his own profession, to a huffing-and-puffing firebrand crusader who wants justice for a woman whom he saw being murdered at a party. Kapur plays the dacoit-turned-street theatre activist with his usual subtle power.

But how does Devgan take on the powerful cabal of minister-and-industrialist, whose sons committed the murder? Get this. By threatening to pee on their carpet. Santoshi has made an '80s-style potboiler which could have had an '80s-style audiences. The same film with greater silences and less verbal sparring would have had more impact. For those of us in the noughties, it's too long, too loud and way too lumbering.

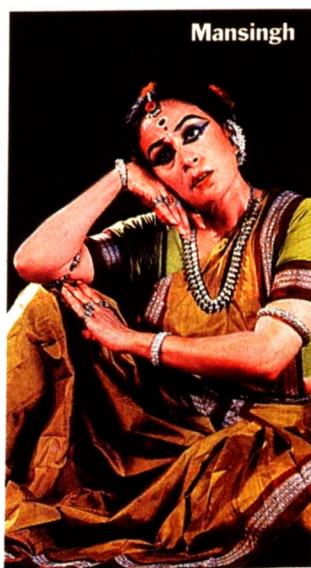
by Kaveer Banzai

recommendation

Divine Play

DELHI For some dancers, dates and events are important as inspiration. Every year in January, around Republic Day, Odissi dancer Sonal Mansingh presents a new idea in a new repertory. This year she performs *Adhbutham: the Miraculous*, one of the nine rasas according to Natyashastra.

The play is based on two incidents from the lives of two great Krishna devo-



tees—Jayadeva, the 12th-century poet from Orissa, and Raskhan, the 16th-century Muslim poet from Delhi. "Both experienced the inexplicable miracle of realising His presence. I believe each one of us has been given the opportunity to do this. Those fortunate enough to relish it experience *adbhutam*. The rest are left floundering in the vast ocean of the trivial and mundane," says Mansingh. A fusion of the modern and traditional on January 25 at the India Habitat Centre.

by S. Sahaya Ranjit

fashion art

Focal Point

BANGALORE An extravaganza of art, fashion and design, 979 is named after the nine designers, seven nationally acclaimed product designers and nine artists who put the show together first in London and now here. With art as the focal point, fashion and product designers took their inspiration from their respective chosen artists to create clothes and lifestyle products. Featured artists



A mixed fare exhibition

include Anjolie Ela Menon, Prabhakar Kolte, Ravinder Reddy, Paresh Maity, Jayasri Burman, Bose Krishnamachari, Jogen Chowdhury, Laxma Goud and Ravikumar Kashi.

Fashion is showcased by Tarun Tahiliani, Namrata Joshipura, Manish Arora, Sabyasachi Mukherjee, Ritu Kumar, Rohit Bal, Rajesh Pratap Singh, Abraham and Thakore, Jason Cheriyan and Anshu Arora Sen. Product designers in the project include Mandira Mallik, Kavita Kanhai, Vikram Sardesai, Mukul Goyal, Suman Sharma and Arun Kullu, Alex Davis and Ayush Kasliwal. "One need only look at a particular fashion, art or furniture to know everything one needs to know about an era," says gallery owner Premilla Baid. At Sumukha Art Gallery till January 15, 2008.

by Nirmala Ravindran